There was an authoritative tone to his voice, almost as though he was already the prime minister. I tried to needle him a bit. ‘What about Jayalalithaa, Mayawati or Mamata, will you take anyone’s support?’ I asked. ‘*Kissi ki zaroorat nahi padegi* [We won’t need anyone], it will be a clear verdict!’ Before I hung up, I had one final journalistic shot. ‘Narendrabhai, you did not give your old friend an interview during the campaign. I hope you will at least give me one once you become prime minister!’ Modi parried the request with ‘*Ab Dilli mein milenge!*’ (We will now meet in Delhi.)

Delhi was already preparing for a change in guard. The only real question was whether Modi would cross 272 comfortably and have an absolute majority or need outside support. Airtel chief Sunil Mittal was hosting a dinner that evening for a few close friends at his Amrita Shergill Road bungalow. To make the evening a little exciting, he announced a competition, asking his guests to come up with the final BJP tally of seats. Whoever came closest to the actual number would get a Franck Muller watch as a reward, the one furthest away would have to host the next dinner.

At the dinner were politicians, media barons and corporate tycoons. Only one of the guests, Meenakshi Dass, from a prominent business family, gave the BJP by itself a figure close to the magical 272 number—her guess was 266. Even Arun Jaitley’s figure was a more modest 245 seats. The media leader at the dinner table gave the least—less than 200 seats. So much for us journalists having our ear to the ground!

Even the RSS was playing it safe. An internal poll done by a Sangh supporter had placed the BJP around the 230-seat mark. ‘We may need to do some post-poll alignment,’ an RSS leader told me. Perhaps it was wishful thinking, since not everyone in the saffron brotherhood was joyous at the prospect of a colossal victory by a dominating personality. In Gujarat, pumped up by repeated electoral victories, Modi tended to ride roughshod over not only his own party but even the Sangh.

Yet there was also genuine concern in a section of the Modi camp over voter turnout numbers. Across India, the turnout had risen, in some states